



FREE STARTER GUIDE

Pack First

A calmer start to emergency preparedness.

What to pack. What to keep at home. What to decide together.



An illustrated guide for everyday families.



01 / THE PURPOSE

Start before the warning

You do not need to buy everything at once. Start with the essentials you already own, then use the checklist to spot what is missing.

This guide helps you organize supplies for a household in the United States. It is not a complete survival manual or a substitute for current local instructions.

During a home fire, leave immediately and stay outside. Do not collect a bag. During a tornado warning, move to your safe shelter immediately; do not pause to pack.

Our bag will be kept here

The adult checking it will be

People come before possessions.



02 / TWO DIFFERENT JOBS

One bag is not your whole supply



GO-BAG: accessible, portable essentials for leaving. Test the packed load against the actual person carrying it.

HOME SUPPLIES: a larger reserve for disruption while staying home is safe. The Red Cross recommends three days of food and water for evacuation and two weeks at home.

Arrange how extra water and food will travel when evacuation transport allows. Never delay urgent escape to move supplies.

Pack for your real transport and mobility needs.



03 / THE MOST IMPORTANT NUMBER

Water: calculate before you pack

1 GALLON

per person / per day

Store at least one US gallon per person per day for three days. This covers drinking and other essential uses. Try to build toward two weeks; heat, illness, pregnancy and pets can increase requirements.

Four people x three days = 12 US gallons, about 45 liters. Water alone weighs about 100 lb / 45 kg. That is household supply planning, not a single-backpack target.

Use sealed commercial water or suitable sanitized food-grade containers. Follow bottled-water dates. Replace water you filled yourself every six months. Store it cool and away from sunlight and chemicals.

People ___ x days ___ = ___ US gallons

Additional water for pets / special needs



04 / LIGHT, FOOD & COMMUNICATION

Pack the basics



Choose food that keeps without refrigeration and is easy to eat. Include a manual opener when needed.

Pack a flashlight, spare batteries, battery or hand-crank radio, phone charging equipment, first-aid kit, hygiene supplies and a whistle.

Add suitable clothing, sturdy shoes and a blanket. Include copies of key documents, paper contacts, a local map and some cash.

Use the checklist on page 10 to track what is packed, rather than treating the illustration as a complete inventory.



05 / PERSONAL ESSENTIALS

Make room for medical needs

Discuss an emergency medicine supply with your pharmacist or clinician. The Red Cross checklist suggests seven days, but your safe and available supply must be planned individually.

Keep a current medicine list, doses, allergies and prescription copies. Protect medicine packaging from water.

For refrigerated medicines, agree on storage and a power-outage plan in advance. Follow the product instructions. A standard insulated bag alone is not a verified cold-storage solution.

Include glasses, hearing-aid batteries and other personal medical supplies. Ask the device provider how essential equipment will work without household power.

Pharmacy and phone

Medical equipment / backup plan

Items to collect at departure, if safe



Pack for your actual family



Include age-appropriate feeding supplies, diapers and a small familiar activity or comfort item for children. Tailor food to allergies and usual needs.

For pets, pack food, water, bowls, medicines, records and a leash or carrier. Confirm an animal-friendly destination in advance; do not assume every shelter houses pets with people.

Assign a helper and backup for anyone needing support with travel or carrying supplies. Make the plan with them.



07 / A CONTACT CARD

Write it down

Agree on an out-of-area contact and meeting places. Keep paper contact details as well as phone copies. Discuss who assists each household member.

Household / names

Out-of-area contact + phone

Meeting place outside the home

Meeting place outside the neighborhood

Person helping children / support needs

Pet transport and destination

Keep completed cards private. Carry them; do not post them online.



08 / OUR PRACTICAL PACKING METHOD

Make the bag usable

Group items into a few clearly marked pouches: light and power, personal care, documents, and food. This is our organizing method, not an official equipment standard.

Try opening and carrying the bag in ordinary conditions. Can you find the flashlight? Can you carry it while helping someone? Remove unnecessary weight and arrange help where needed.

Attach a short reminder for items used daily, such as a phone or refrigerated medicine. That reminder never overrides urgent evacuation or shelter instructions.

What was difficult to carry or find?

What we will change

Next check date

Practice calmly, without creating a simulated emergency.



Your packing checklist

Mark an item only when it is ready. Add your household-specific quantities. Keep extra supplies separate if needed for transport.

- ☐ Water + plan for additional supply
- ☐ Food that meets our needs + opener if needed
- ☐ Flashlight + compatible spare batteries
- ☐ Radio + phone charging equipment
- ☐ First-aid supplies + personal medicines
- ☐ Hygiene supplies + clothing + blanket
- ☐ Document copies + cash + paper contacts
- ☐ Local map + keys + whistle
- ☐ Children's specific supplies
- ☐ Pet supplies + leash / carrier
- ☐ Medical aids + arranged assistance
- ☐ Daily-use collection reminder



10 / YOUR NEXT ACTION

Finish one useful step today

Choose a bag, gather what you have, and write the three most important gaps below. Small completed steps are more useful than a perfect list left untouched.

Check expiry dates and equipment condition regularly. Review the kit whenever your household, medicines or season changes. Follow manufacturers' storage and charging instructions.

Once your equipment is organized, build the rest of your family plan: alerts, transport, shelter, communication and who helps whom.

Gap 1 / person responsible

Gap 2 / person responsible

Gap 3 / person responsible

Our review date

Preparation is something you can do together.



REFERENCE / US EDITION

Sources & scope

General preparedness information, checked September 12, 2026. These public sources support the safety guidance. Our organization, worksheets and illustrations are original.

Follow local emergency officials and individual medical advice. SECONDS LEFT is independent and is not endorsed by the organizations cited. Illustrations are illustrative, not complete technical instructions.

Editorial edition 1.0. External emergency-preparedness professional review has not yet been completed.

- [1] American Red Cross | Survival kit supplies
- [2] CDC | Emergency water supply
- [3] FDA | Safe drug use after a natural disaster
- [4] American Red Cross | Make a plan
- [5] American Red Cross | Pet preparedness
- [6] NWS | During a tornado
- [7] American Red Cross | Home fire safety
- [8] Ready.gov | Build a kit